
A bird's-eye view of Tamara Kodai

Kodaikanal, Tamil Nadu

Set up as a European sanatorium in 1845 by the American Madura Mission, Kodaikanal is a welcome respite from the heat of the plains. The thick Shola rainforests, the purple kurinji (*Strobilanthes kunthiana*) that flowers every 12 years, and 17 trekking trails make Kodai a paradise for nature lovers. The starfish-shaped lake forms the town's core with churches, hotels, restaurants and numerous sights—Coaker's Walk, Bryant Park, the century-old Kodai Golf Club, Green Valley View, Pillar Rocks, Bear Shola Falls and the Kurinji Andavar Temple, dedicated to Lord Murugan/Subramanya, the Lord of the Palani Hills. Stay at the scenic Tamara Kodai on Upper Lake Road with a spa and temperature-controlled pool (from Rs 15,000; 8071077701, *www.thetamara.com*).


Jaagir Manor

Dudhwa, Uttar Pradesh



Unlike commercial tiger parks, Dudhwa is an offbeat wildlife destination in the *terai* or Himalayan foothills at the Indo-Nepal border. Enjoy jeep safaris in the 811 sq. km Kishanpur Wildlife Sanctuary separated from Dudhwa National Park by 15 km of agricultural land. The fertile Indo-Gangetic plains support an astonishing diversity of fauna with pristine sal forests. The park is mostly a vast alluvial plain along the tributaries of Mohana and Suheli rivers, interspersed with rivulets, lakes, marshes, grasslands and forests, where one can spot *barasingha* (swamp deer), tigers, crocodiles and 450 species of birds. Stay at Jaagir Manor, an IHCL SeleQtions property (from Rs 20,500; 9871555141, *seleqtionshotels.com*) and explore both parks; book a jeep safari with local operator Gulab (8127332465).

Getting there: Fly to Lucknow and drive 228 km to Dudhwa via Lakhimpur Kheri and Kishanpur




Common area and lawn at Tamara Kodai

Getting there: Fly to Madurai Airport and drive 132 km to Kodai